# *Chapter Fifty-Five*

## Kublai Khan

*Between 1273 and 1294,*
*Kublai Khan conquers China,*
*tries to subdue Champa,*
*fails to conquer the Dai Viet and Japan,*
*and becomes the first Yuan emperor*

THE GREAT KHAN had lost three-quarters of his empire, but the quarter that remained to him was vast: the Mongol homeland, with Karakorum at its heart and the enormous sweep of plateaus north and west; the land seized from the Western Xia and the Jin and from Goryeo; the entire north of the Song.

The rich fields in the Yangtze river valley, and the lands below it, were still unconquered.

Those southern lands, the last remaining to the Song, were still ruled by the emperor Song Duzong. Few men could have gracefully maintained a court, in the face of the relentless and frightening Mongol aggression; Song Duzong was not one of the few. He turned to wine and feasting, his harem of concubines, gambling and games to distract himself from the coming end.[1]

For five years, the Mongol armies had been laying siege to the double city of Xiangyang and Fancheng, on the northern and southern banks of the western Yangtze: the gate to the south. In the early years of the assault, the